



RAJ AFTER THE POLL RESULTS WERE OUT; UDDHAV, MUNDE AND JOSHI SHOW A UNITED FRONT (BELOW)

tunes of the BJP and its future will depend on the quality of introspection at the Centre. In Mumbai all attention will be on the future of the Sena.

It took Bal Thackeray nearly two decades to take the Shiv Sena beyond the single-digit mark in the Assembly. His protégé has done it in just three short years since quitting the party. He chose to go back to the original plank of the Shiv Sena, the marathi *manoos* that the Sena had dumped when it adopted Hindutva along with the BJP in its quest for national rele-

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THE SAFFRON COMBINE FAILED TO CONVERT 10 years of anti-incumbency. It was BJP vs BJP and Thackeray vs Thackeray enabling a Cong-NCP win.

Independent candidates, going against the party has not paid off. Whether it is former BJP leader Vinay Nattu, contesting as an Independent from Guhagar, Shalinitai Patil, a sitting MLA from Koregaon or state cabinet minister Sunil Deshmukh, all have been trounced. Says veteran Congress MP Eknath Gaikwad, "The rule of thumb in politics is to work continuously and be patient." It didn't matter which side the rebels fought from. Rebel candidates Digvijay Khanvilkar, originally from the NCP and erstwhile Shiv Sainik

Sada Sarvankar met a similar fate from their respective constituencies of Kolhapur South and Mahim. Says Congress spokesperson Sanjay Dutt, "In these elections, people have realised that it is better to vote for a party, an ideology or an agenda instead of voting for the individual. It is a lesson that those who rebelled should learn."

But the big rebel has won the day. Raj has acquired the legitimacy to challenge the existence of the Shiv Sena. In the process he has reduced the BJP tally to its lowest in two decades. The for-

vance. It is quite obvious that his victory will result in a slow decimation of the original Shiv Sena. Uddhav and his father Bal Thackeray are faced with some hard questions.

The emergence of Raj Thackeray is not a headache just for the Shiv Sena. It will be a phenomenon the Congress-NCP too will have to learn to deal with. Unlike the BJP or the Shiv Sena, the MNS is a hungry group of combative politicians. They will want to be heard and will work to carve a larger empire. The third term of the Democratic Front will definitely not be without opposition. This government, as the Chinese would say, will live in interesting times.

with inputs from Nishika Patel and Mitail Patel